

DIAMOND OPEN ACCESS • EDITORIAL BRIEFING

Getting AIDER into DOAJ

What it takes, why it matters, and where we stand — now that the ISSN is in hand.

Second editors' online meetup • Saturday 1 August 2026 • 9:00–9:30 pm Beijing (UTC+8) • ISSN 2979-8639 (Online)

We now hold our **ISSN (2979-8639, Online)**. The next credibility gate is the **Directory of Open Access Journals (DOAJ)**. This briefing explains what DOAJ is, why it is the single highest-value listing we can pursue right now, exactly what it requires, and an honest scorecard of where AIDER already qualifies and where we have work to do — plus the other issues on today's agenda. **Every criterion cited is sourced to DOAJ's own materials**; references are on the final page.

Today's Agenda (~30 minutes)

Time	Item
3 min	Welcome; the ISSN is assigned — what it unlocks and what comes next.
6 min	DOAJ 101 : what it is and why it is our next gate (§1).
8 min	The readiness scorecard : requirements vs. where AIDER stands (§2–§3).
5 min	The AI-review question : DOAJ's new AI guidance vs. our five-agent model (§4).
6 min	Other issues : Crossref DOIs & preservation, publishing cadence & the 5th paper, post-ISSN promotion (§5).
2 min	Next steps & owners (§6).

1 What DOAJ Is — and Why It Is Our Next Gate

The **Directory of Open Access Journals** (doaj.org) is the community-curated, independent index of vetted open-access journals — **more than 20,000** titles from around **130** countries, all screened against a public set of criteria. [1] It is not a paywall database and it charges nothing; it is the sector's *whitelist*. In our own first-meetup briefing we already named DOAJ “the credibility floor” — this is the meeting where we go and stand on it.

Four reasons it is the highest-value move available to us today:

- **It is the trust signal.** For a young, independent journal, *being in DOAJ* is the fastest way to say “we are legitimate, not predatory.” Being *absent* is a red flag librarians and authors actively screen for. DOAJ inclusion certifies verified ownership, a real editorial process, and genuine open access. [1,2]
- **It makes our work findable everywhere.** DOAJ metadata is openly harvestable and flows into library discovery systems, aggregators, and downstream indexes. A listed journal's articles are pulled into the places researchers actually search — for free. [2]
- **It is the on-ramp to everything above it.** Scopus, Web of Science, and funders treat DOAJ membership as a baseline. Under **Plan S / cOAlition S**, a journal must be registered in DOAJ to count as a compliant open-access venue — so DOAJ listing is what lets grant-funded authors publish with us at all. [3]
- **It is free, and we finally clear the entry gate.** DOAJ requires an ISSN before it will even review an application. We now have one. The one thing that blocked us is gone. [1]

In one line. DOAJ is the free, independent whitelist that turns “a website with papers” into “an indexed, fundable, discoverable journal.” The ISSN was the key to the door; DOAJ is the room we walk into next.

2 What DOAJ Requires

DOAJ publishes its full criteria in the *Guide to Applying*, revised on a quarterly schedule since 2025. [1,4] They fall into five groups. The first two are hard eligibility gates; the last (the *Seal*) is best-practice that only ~10% of listed journals achieve — and it maps almost exactly onto AIDER’s design goals. [5]

2.1 Eligibility gates (must be met to be listed)

- **A valid online ISSN**, registered and confirmed with the ISSN organisation. [1]
- **Fully open access**: immediate, free-to-read, no embargo, under an open license — and *fully* OA, not hybrid. [1]
- **A track record**: a **1+ year** history of fully-OA publishing *or* at least **10** OA research articles already published. [1]
- **A sustained cadence**: consistently ≥ 5 scholarly research articles per year, aimed at researchers or practitioners. [1]

2.2 Editorial & peer-review requirements

- **Quality control before publication**: every article passes peer review, and the *type* of review (e.g. anonymous, double-anonymous, editorial) is stated plainly on the site. For STEM, at least **two** qualified external referees per article. [1]
- **A named editorial board** of at least five members with appropriate qualifications, each listed with **name and institutional affiliation**. [1]
- **Low endogeneity**: papers authored by the journal’s own editors/board **must not exceed 25%** of content. [1]

2.3 Website disclosures (specific pages DOAJ checks)

Aims & scope; author instructions; a described peer-review process; a dedicated **open-access statement**; **licensing terms**; a dedicated **copyright policy**; a clear statement of **author fees** (or that there are none); a **plagiarism/screening** policy; publication ethics; and a typical **time from submission to publication**. [1,2]

2.4 Licensing & author rights

An open license (Creative Commons recommended); the license **embedded or displayed in every article**; and authors **retaining their rights**. [1]

2.5 The DOAJ Seal — seven best-practice criteria

The Seal is awarded only when *all seven* are met; roughly one journal in ten qualifies. [5]

1. External long-term **preservation** arrangement (CLOCKSS, LOCKSS, Portico, or equivalent).
2. **Persistent article identifiers** (DOI, ARK, or Handle) that resolve correctly.
3. **Article-level metadata supplied to DOAJ**, regularly.
4. **Machine-readable CC licensing** embedded in that metadata.
5. A qualifying license — **CC BY, CC BY-SA, or CC BY-NC** (derivatives allowed).

6. A **self-archiving / deposit policy** registered in a directory such as SHERPA/RoMEO.
7. Authors **hold copyright without restriction**.

New in 2025 — and it points straight at us. DOAJ has added AI best-practices (advisory now, “under review to become requirements”): journals *should publish an AI policy*; authors must disclose generative-AI use beyond routine language editing; AI tools may not be listed as authors or cited as sources; and, pointedly, “**peer reviewers and editors should not use generative AI for assessments**,” while any automated tooling must operate under transparent **human oversight**. [6] AIDER’s whole model is five AI reviewer agents — so this is not a footnote for us; it is §4.

3 Where AIDER Stands — The Readiness Scorecard

An honest audit against every criterion above. **Green** = already satisfied; **amber** = partially there, small work to finish; **grey** = not started; **at risk** = a real threat to acceptance we must actively manage.

DOAJ requirement	Status	Where we are / what closes it
<i>Eligibility gates</i>		
Valid online ISSN	MET	2979-8639 (Online) , assigned June 2026. Done.
Fully OA, immediate, no embargo	MET	All content free on GitHub Pages under CC-BY 4.0; no paywall, no APC.
1+ yr history <i>or</i> ≥ 10 articles	TO DO	4 published + a 5th in review. One-year mark lands ~Mar 2027; or reach 10 articles sooner. <i>This is our binding gate.</i>
Consistently ≥ 5 articles/year	PARTIAL	Vol. 1 reaches 5 the moment paper #5 publishes; the task is to <i>sustain</i> it into 2027.
<i>Editorial & review</i>		
Peer review before publication, type stated	PARTIAL	AI-assisted screening + a human-editor accept/reject gate exists; we must state the review <i>type</i> explicitly on the site (see §4).
Editorial board ≥ 5 , names + affiliations	MET	9 founding editors listed with institutions.
Editor-authored content $\leq 25\%$	AT RISK	All 4 current papers are editor-authored (~100%). Must recruit external authors before applying.
<i>Website disclosures</i>		
Aims & scope, author & reviewer guidelines	MET	Pages already live.
Open-access statement (dedicated URL)	TO DO	Add a formal OA-policy page (DOAJ gives boilerplate wording).
Copyright policy (dedicated URL)	TO DO	Add a standalone copyright-policy page.
Author-fees / “no charges” statement	TO DO	Add an explicit “diamond — no author or reader fees” page.
Plagiarism / ethics policy	PARTIAL	Ethics page exists; add an explicit screening statement.
Typical submission→publication time	TO DO	Publish a typical timeline figure.
<i>Licensing, rights & Seal</i>		
Open CC license (BY / BY-SA / BY-NC)	MET	CC-BY 4.0 throughout — Seal-qualifying.
License shown in every article	PARTIAL	Add a CC-BY notice to each paper’s page/PDF.
Authors retain copyright, unrestricted	MET	CC-BY: authors keep copyright.
Persistent identifiers (DOI)	MET	Zenodo DOIs on published articles (Crossref optional — §5).

DOAJ requirement	Status	Where we are / what closes it
External preservation arrangement	PARTIAL	Zenodo (CERN-backed) archives our record; document it as our preservation arrangement.
Deposit policy in SHERPA/RoMEO	TO DO	Register a self-archiving policy.
Article metadata to DOAJ	TO DO	Supplied after acceptance (machine-readable CC).
<i>AI-era best practice (2025)</i>		
Published AI-use policy	TO DO	Publish one — our transparency becomes a selling point, not a liability (§4).
Human oversight of automated review	PARTIAL	Human editor is the accountable gate; we must document it that way.

Readiness at a glance. The *hard* blockers are few: (1) the **track-record gate** — reach 10 articles or the one-year mark; (2) **endogeny** — get real external authors; and (3) frame the **AI-review model** correctly. Everything else is a handful of website pages and metadata housekeeping we can finish in a weekend. **We are closer than we look.**

4 The AI-Review Question — Our Sharpest Issue

DOAJ’s 2025 guidance says, in plain words, that “*peer reviewers and editors should not use generative AI for assessments*,” and that any automated tooling must run under transparent human oversight. [6] AIDER’s core mechanism is **five AI reviewer agents**. On the surface this looks like a collision. It is actually our opportunity — if we frame and document it deliberately.

- **The human editor is the “quality control system,” not the AI.** DOAJ requires that peer review happen before publication and that a human editorial gate makes the accept/reject call. Our agents produce a *structured report* — reproducibility checks, claim auditing, reference verification — that a human editor then adjudicates. We should state exactly this on the reviewer-guidelines page: **agents assist; a named human decides.**
- **We are *more* transparent than the norm, not less.** DOAJ’s worry is undisclosed, unaccountable AI. We publish the entire AI review log for every paper. Radical transparency is precisely the posture DOAJ’s “human oversight + transparency” language rewards — we just have to say so.
- **Publish an AI-use policy now** (it is on DOAJ’s list anyway). It should spell out: what the agents do; that they never make the final decision; that AI is not credited as an author or reviewer-of-record; and how a human editor signs off. This one document turns our biggest question mark into a compliance *asset*.

Decision for today. Do we (a) present the human editor as the formal reviewer and the agents as disclosed tooling, and (b) commit to writing and publishing an AIDER AI-use policy before we apply? Recommended: **yes to both**. It costs us one page and removes the only criterion where a reviewer might hesitate.

5 The Other Issues on the Table

5.1 Crossref DOIs & digital preservation

Zenodo already gives every article a free, permanent DOI and CERN-backed archival — which satisfies the Seal’s persistent-identifier and preservation criteria today. The optional upgrade is a **Crossref membership** (~\$275/yr) to mint DOIs *under our own prefix* rather than Zenodo’s, which reads as more journal-native and feeds Crossref’s citation graph. **Question:** do we spend the \$275 now, or stay on free Zenodo DOIs until after DOAJ acceptance? (Recommended: stay on Zenodo for the

application; revisit Crossref once cadence is proven.) We should also **register a SHERPA/RoMEO deposit policy** — free, and it closes a Seal criterion.

5.2 Publishing cadence & the fifth paper

The binding eligibility gate is the track record: **10 articles or a one-year history, plus ≥ 5 /year sustained**. Two moves: **(i)** Raul completes the review so paper #5 publishes and closes Volume 1 at five; **(ii)** we open the pipeline to **external authors** — which simultaneously fixes the 25% endogeneity risk (§3) and pushes us toward 10 articles. These are the same task viewed twice: *recruit non-editor authors now*.

5.3 Post-ISSN promotion

With the ISSN assigned, the June-13 hold on wider outreach is lifted. Low-risk, high-value first steps: verify our articles surface in **Google Scholar** and **OpenAlex**; announce the ISSN through the board's personal networks (not mass email); and line up external submissions from those networks. The DOAJ application itself becomes a promotion milestone we can announce.

6 Proposed Next Steps & Owners

Action	Owner	When
Finish review of paper #5 so Vol. 1 closes at five articles	Raul	This month
Recruit external (non-editor) authors — cut endogeneity & push to 10 articles	All editors	Ongoing
Add website pages: OA policy, copyright policy, “no fees” statement, review-type + timing	Jianou	1–2 weeks
Draft & publish the AIDER AI-use policy (§4)	Jianou + board	2 weeks
Embed a CC-BY notice + DOI on every article page/PDF	Jianou	1–2 weeks
Register a SHERPA/RoMEO deposit policy	Jianou	2 weeks
Decide on Crossref membership (\$275/yr) vs. staying on Zenodo DOIs	Board vote	Today
File the DOAJ application once the track-record gate clears (≥ 10 articles or ~Mar 2027)	Jianou	Q4 2026 / Q1 2027
Reconvene to review the application draft before submission	All	Next meetup

The through-line. Almost every gap collapses into one action — **publish more papers by more (external) authors**. That single push clears the track-record gate, fixes endogeneity, and proves cadence. The rest is a weekend of website pages and one AI-use policy. DOAJ is genuinely within reach this cycle.

References

- DOAJ. *Guide to Applying* (journal eligibility criteria: ISSN, full OA, 1-yr / 10-article history, ≥ 5 articles/yr, peer review, editorial board, $\leq 25\%$ endogeneity, required website disclosures, licensing). doaj.org/apply/guide.
- Scholastica. *How to get OA journals indexed in the DOAJ: an updated guide* (detailed walk-through of DOAJ's required website content and application questions). blog.scholasticahq.com.
- cOAlition S. *Plan S Principles & the Journal Checker Tool* — fully-OA journals must be registered in DOAJ to be Plan S compliant. coalition-s.org.
- DOAJ Blog (10 Jul 2025). *Quarterly updates to DOAJ Criteria from 2025*. blog.doaj.org.
- DOAJ. *The DOAJ Seal* — the seven best-practice criteria (preservation, persistent IDs, metadata to DOAJ, machine-readable CC, CC BY/BY-SA/BY-NC, SHERPA/RoMEO deposit policy, unrestricted author copyright); held by $\sim 10\%$ of listed journals. doaj.org/apply/seal.

6. DOAJ Blog (3 Nov 2025). *Updates to the Guide to Applying — flipped journals, AI, quality criteria, and OA exceptions* (AI best-practice: publish an AI policy; disclose GenAI use; no AI authors or cited AI sources; reviewers/editors should not use GenAI for assessments; transparent human oversight). blog.doaj.org.

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